ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Passives across tenses

Build passive clauses accurately in continuous, perfect and modal forms while deciding whether the agent matters. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use passives across tenses to shift attention from the actor to the process, result or affected participant while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Build passive clauses accurately in continuous, perfect and modal forms while deciding whether the agent matters.

MODEL

The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

tense/modal + be + past participle | optional by-agent

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main passives across tenses patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses shift attention from the actor to the process, result or affected participant.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in reports, processes, news, scientific description and formal updates.

Build meaning before form

Build passive clauses accurately in continuous, perfect and modal forms while deciding whether the agent matters.

What passives across tenses communicates

Build passive clauses accurately in continuous, perfect and modal forms while deciding whether the agent matters.

The central purpose is to shift attention from the actor to the process, result or affected participant. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The bridge is being inspected this week.	a passive process currently in progress
The new protocol has been tested in three departments.	a completed passive result connected to a reference point
All entries must be submitted electronically.	a required or possible action with the receiver in focus

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: tense/modal + be + past participle | optional by-agent. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The new protocol has been tested in three departments.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Ongoing passive	is/was being + participle	The bridge is being inspected this week.
Perfect passive	has/had been + participle	The new protocol has been tested in three departments.
Modal passive	modal + be + participle	All entries must be submitted electronically.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a passive process currently in progress	Ongoing passive
a completed passive result connected to a reference point	Perfect passive
a required or possible action with the receiver in focus	Modal passive

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in reports, processes, news, scientific description and formal updates. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
tense/modal	be	past participle	optional by-agent

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: shift attention from the actor to the process, result or affected participant.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits reports, processes, news, scientific description and formal updates.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Ongoing passive	is/was being + participle	The bridge is being inspected this week.
Perfect passive	has/had been + participle	The new protocol has been tested in three departments.
Modal passive	modal + be + participle	All entries must be submitted electronically.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The bridge is being inspected this week.	a passive process currently in progress
The new protocol has been tested in three departments.	a completed passive result connected to a reference point
All entries must be submitted electronically.	a required or possible action with the receiver in focus

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not omit being in a continuous passive.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use has being in the present perfect passive.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not place to between the modal and be.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a passive process currently in progress?

OPTIONS The bridge is being inspected this week. · The new protocol has been tested in three departments. · All entries must be submitted electronically.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a completed passive result connected to a reference point?

OPTIONS The new protocol has been tested in three departments. · All entries must be submitted electronically. · The bridge is being inspected this week.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a required or possible action with the receiver in focus?

OPTIONS All entries must be submitted electronically. · The bridge is being inspected this week. · The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The bridge is being inspected this week.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a passive process currently in progress · a completed passive result connected to a reference point · a required or possible action with the receiver in focus

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The new protocol has been tested in three departments.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a completed passive result connected to a reference point · a required or possible action with the receiver in focus · a passive process currently in progress

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “All entries must be submitted electronically.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a required or possible action with the receiver in focus · a passive process currently in progress · a completed passive result connected to a reference point

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The bridge is being inspected this week." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Ongoing passive / Perfect passive / Modal passive · Gap 2: a passive process currently in progress / a completed passive result connected to a reference point / a required or possible action with the receiver in focus

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The new protocol has been tested in three departments." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Perfect passive / Modal passive / Ongoing passive · Gap 2: a completed passive result connected to a reference point / a required or possible action with the receiver in focus / a passive process currently in progress

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"All entries must be submitted electronically." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Modal passive / Ongoing passive / Perfect passive · Gap 2: a required or possible action with the receiver in focus / a passive process currently in progress / a completed passive result connected to a reference point

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a passive process currently in progress: _____. Choose the model that expresses a completed passive result connected to a reference point: _____. Choose the model that expresses a required or possible action with the receiver in focus: _____. Choose the model built with is/was being + participle: _____. Choose the model built with has/had been + participle: _____. Choose the model built with modal + be + participle: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

All entries must be submitted electronically. · The bridge is being inspected this week. · The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

04 · PRACTICE STAGE

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The bridge _____ this week. The new protocol _____ in three departments. All entries _____ electronically. State the full structural pattern for Ongoing passive: _____. State the full structural pattern for Perfect passive: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Inspectors are examining the bridge this week.” using the Ongoing passive pattern to express a passive process currently in progress.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Three departments have completed tests of the protocol.” using the Perfect passive pattern to express a completed passive result connected to a reference point.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Everyone must submit entries electronically.” using the Modal passive pattern to express a required or possible action with the receiver in focus.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Inspectors are examining the bridge this week.” using the Ongoing passive pattern to express a passive process currently in progress.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Ongoing passive to express a passive process currently in progress, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Perfect passive to express a completed passive result connected to a reference point, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Modal passive to express a required or possible action with the receiver in focus, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The bridge is being inspected this week.

Ongoing passive is the best match because a passive process currently in progress.

A2

The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

Perfect passive is the best match because a completed passive result connected to a reference point.

A3

All entries must be submitted electronically.

Modal passive is the best match because a required or possible action with the receiver in focus.

A4

a passive process currently in progress

The Ongoing passive pattern communicates a passive process currently in progress.

A5

a completed passive result connected to a reference point

The Perfect passive pattern communicates a completed passive result connected to a reference point.

A6

a required or possible action with the receiver in focus

The Modal passive pattern communicates a required or possible action with the receiver in focus.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Ongoing passive / a passive process currently in progress

The structure belongs to the Ongoing passive pattern. Its communicative purpose is a passive process currently in progress.

B2

Perfect passive / a completed passive result connected to a reference point

The structure belongs to the Perfect passive pattern. Its communicative purpose is a completed passive result connected to a reference point.

B3

Modal passive / a required or possible action with the receiver in focus

The structure belongs to the Modal passive pattern. Its communicative purpose is a required or possible action with the receiver in focus.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The bridge is being inspected this week.

Ongoing passive: is/was being + participle.

C2

The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

Perfect passive: has/had been + participle.

C3

All entries must be submitted electronically.

Modal passive: modal + be + participle.

C4

The bridge is being inspected this week.

Ongoing passive: is/was being + participle.

C5

The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

Perfect passive: has/had been + participle.

C6

All entries must be submitted electronically.

Modal passive: modal + be + participle.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

is being inspected

Ongoing passive requires “is being inspected” in this model. is/was being + participle.

D2

has been tested

Perfect passive requires “has been tested” in this model. has/had been + participle.

D3

must be submitted

Modal passive requires “must be submitted” in this model. modal + be + participle.

D4

is/was being + participle

Ongoing passive is built as is/was being + participle.

D5

has/had been + participle

Perfect passive is built as has/had been + participle.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The bridge is being inspected this week.

is/was being + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended ongoing passive effect.

E2

The new protocol has been tested in three departments.

has/had been + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended perfect passive effect.

E3

All entries must be submitted electronically.

modal + be + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended modal passive effect.

E4

The bridge is being inspected this week.

is/was being + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended ongoing passive effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The bridge is being inspected this week. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses is/was being + participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The new protocol has been tested in three departments. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses has/had been + participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

All entries must be submitted electronically. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses modal + be + participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____